

Scene 4: Approaching Rjocht - Getting Inside

TIME

~15-20 minutes

PURPOSE

Reward intel gathering • Multiple approaches • Show oppression • Problem-solving

FIRST SIGHT

The forest opens. Rjocht rises before you - massive stone walls, dark and imposing. Once-beautiful towers now grim and oppressive. The city that fell at the end of the First Age, still held in shadow.

The Blade runs ice-cold. Drachan's corruption is thick here.

Main gates: 4-6 corrupted soldiers in black armor, cruel-looking. East side: smaller market gate (if they look/know about it).

OPTION A: EAST MARKET GATE (if they have Jasper's intel)

Two guards: TAM (young, nervous) and BEREN (older, tired). Overheard: 'My sister's kids haven't had meat in two weeks...'
'At least you get paid. My neighbor lost everything to Dorogh's taxes...'

Approaches:

- Talk (Heart/Wit, roll 12+): They let you through
 - Wait for watch change (Agility 10+): Sneak through
 - Bribe with food: They take it gratefully
 - Show compassion (Heart 14+): They help willingly
- If fail or cold: They won't help but won't attack. Find another way.

OPTION B: MAIN GATE (hard)

4 Corrupted Guards: HP 2 each, Armor Yes, Defense 16, Attack 11
Loud fight, attracts attention. Or very hard deception (Wit 18+).

OPTION C: CREATIVE

Scale walls Agility 16+, find tunnels Insight 16+, etc.

INSIDE THE CITY - THE BLEAKNESS

Streets functional, nothing more. Market sells potatoes, carrots, turnips - no herbs, no spices. Potter has plain clay pots - no decoration, no color. Everything that made this city worth living in has been drained away.

People hurry past, heads down. No music. No children playing. Guards patrol in pairs. The weight of oppression is physical. In distance: the fortress keep, dark stone, narrow windows. That's where Dorogh waits.

Blade is ice-cold now, almost painful.

OPTIONAL: Kael the Blacksmith (if they know about him)

Eastern district, near inner wall. Working on plain iron hinge - no flourishes, no pride.

If they mention Jasper: [Looks around nervously] 'Jasper made it out? Good. You're here for Dorogh. I can't fight - I have family. But:

Dorogh never leaves the keep. Sits on the throne, feeding on our fear. His corrupted guards are few inside - most patrol the city. Keep's front entrance has guards but not many. Get past them, you'll find him.

When you strike, strike true. End this. The moment he falls, we'll rise up. I promise. We're not all broken yet.'

[Gives Healing Potion] 'You'll need this more than I do. The Spirit of Life go with you.'

TRANSITION

You make your way through defeated streets toward the fortress keep. The closer you get, the colder the Blade becomes. The keep looms. And standing at its entrance...